



F R I D A Y

FAITHFULNESS:

A FRUIT OF LOVE

“But the fruit of the Spirit is love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, self-control; against such things there is no law.”

Galatians 5:22, 23

Let's learn about fruit from around the World:

MATOKE

Matoke is a staple fruit in East Africa. It belongs to the banana family. It is green on the outside and white on the inside. Matoke fruit is used mainly for cooking when they are green and unripe. It is cooked very similarly to potatoes. They need to soften and cook through to be eaten. It has a savory taste, with very little sweetness, making it a great companion to several main dishes.

The fruit is harvested green, carefully peeled, and then cooked and often mashed or pounded into a meal. In Uganda and Rwanda, the fruit is steam-cooked, and the mashed meal is considered a national dish in both countries.

TODAY'S SPIRITUAL FRUIT IS

FAITHFULNESS

Galatians 5:22 and 23 reads: “But the fruit of the Spirit is love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, **faithfulness**, gentleness, self-control; against such things there is no law.”

Dictionary.com defines faithfulness as: “lasting loyalty and trustworthiness in relationships, especially marriage and friendship.” Also, “the fact or quality of being true to one’s word or commitments, as to what one has pledged to do, professes to believe.” And, “the fact or quality of being dedicated and steadfast in performing one’s duty, working for a cause.”

This is the *Family Togetherness Week of Prayer*, an apt opportunity to highlight faithfulness as a fruit of love that comes from being filled with the Spirit of God. True faithfulness in our relationship with others—especially in our families—is fueled by God’s love in us. Each time we keep our promises to one another and are loyal to each other in our family relationships it demonstrates the fruit of God’s love in our hearts. Every time we are faithful to our marriage vows, whether at home or on a business trip, we display the fruit of love through our faithfulness.

While faithfulness is an outcome of life in the Spirit (vs. 22), sexual immorality, impurity, indecent behavior (vs. 19) are indications of the desires of the flesh at work. We must ask ourselves the question: am I faithful like Joseph was when he was tempted by Potiphar’s wife? Joseph’s response to Mrs. Potiphar’s inappropriate advances was: “How then could I do this great evil, and sin against God?” (Gen 39:9). Being filled with the Spirit of God means having the fuel to walk by the Spirit in faithfulness and at once standing against the desires of the flesh. These two forces are antagonistic, contradictory, discordant and incompatible with each other. One

comes from the One Who is the light, while the other comes from the prince of darkness.

We each have been given the choice to either walk by the Spirit (vss. 22, 23) or to engage in the deeds of the flesh (vss. 19-21). To walk by the Spirit means we will bear the fruit of obedience, which is what faithfulness is all about.

Addressing what it means to live a life of faithfulness Ellen White shares in *The Ministry of Healing*: “We need constantly a fresh revelation of Christ, a daily experience that harmonizes with His teachings. High and holy attainments are within our reach. Continual progress in knowledge and virtue is God’s purpose for us” (*The Ministry of Healing*, p. 503).

Yes, faithfulness is only faithfulness when we continue to grow in our daily walk with Jesus and live a life compatible with His teachings. This is only achievable when we are filled with God’s Spirit. So, pick the fruit of **faithfulness** today, not only in the easy matters of your family relationships, but also in the more difficult and challenging ones that demonstrate you have chosen to walk with Jesus.

May God bless us to be faithful today and every day until Jesus comes again.

PRAY:

Dear Lord, thank You for loving us so much that You stay close to us no matter what we do or where we go. Help us to remain steadfast in our love and in our faithfulness to You and to each other. In the name of Jesus, amen.



FRUITFUL **FAITHFULNESS** ACTIVITY

You will need:

- Objects to create a short obstacle course, either indoors, on a carpet, or outside on soft grass.
- Soft scarf or fabric to use as a blindfold.

Instructions:

- Set up an obstacle course with safe items to walk around, a blanket to crawl under, something low to climb over, etc. try to include about 5-6 different objects to negotiate.
- Then, blindfold each child in turn and have an adult guiding them carefully and safely through the obstacles.
- The adult will always make sure the child is safe, but holding their hand, and/or, giving them very clear instructions about how to move under and around objects.
- Once every child has been safely guided through the obstacles, sit down together and talk about the experience. The adult is faithful to the child. They are committed to keeping them safe and being with them through the ups and downs of their journey, and they don't let them down. How is this like God's faithfulness to us? How we can be faithful to God and to others, even when life is difficult?



BIBLE VERSE ACTIVITY

You will need:

- Large, smooth, pale stones; paint, permanent marker pens, etc.; varnish/sealant/slightly diluted white PVA glue.

Instructions:

- Clean the stones and paint them with a pale color. When they are dry, use paint or permanent marker pens to write each word of the verse, and the Bible reference on a separate stone.
- Take it in turns to arrange them in the correct order for the verse, until you have learned it well.
- If you wish, you could varnish/seal the stones to protect the paint and writing. Perhaps you could arrange them in your garden, or by your doorstep, to remind people to be faithful.
- You could also write an encouraging Bible verse or word on a colorful stone, varnish/seal it and leave it for someone to find. Or you could give it to them as a little gift, to encourage them to be faithful.

— **QUESTIONS** — TO TALK ABOUT TOGETHER

- I think faithfulness is...
- Faithfulness is a fruit of the Spirit because...
- Jesus showed us how to be faithful when He...
- Other Bible characters who were faithful to God and others were...
- I find it hardest to be faithful/loyal/trustworthy when...
- Some things that help me to be faithful/loyal/trustworthy are...
- One time that I tried to be faithful this week was when...
- We can help each other to be faithful to God by...
- Pray: Thank You, God, for helping us to be faithful this week when...